



TINOS GREECE

An Easter Feast on Tinos

Easter is the biggest event of the year in Greece – and nowhere is it celebrated with greater aplomb than on the island of Tinos in the Cyclades. The solemnity of the midnight mass is finally broken by firecrackers; congregations embrace and depart in candlelit processions that shimmer through the villages, descending on the tavernas to break the 40-day Lenten fast with 24 hours of feasting.



Every year, thousands of Greeks in search of salvation flock to the miracle-working church of Panagia Evangelistria, on a hill above Tinos town (also known as Chora), the island's capital. But Tinos is also a Mecca for epicures and artists seeking solace in the whitewashed villages lodged in the folds of thyme-scented hills. Ancient footpaths crisscross the terraced valleys, and a hiker's sole companions are inquisitive goats and indifferent sheep.

Traditions run deep on Tinos, an island saved from overdevelopment by the all-powerful Greek Orthodox church. Apprentices still chip away at the marble sculpture school in Pyrgos. Old men thread baskets by hand in Volax, a hamlet built around a mysterious cluster of boulders like giant bowling balls. Kids play hopscotch among the flowerpots on the main street of Agapi – a village endearingly called “Love.”

Easter is the main event on the island, and the centerpiece of the Orthodox Easter feast is spring lamb, naturally flavored with the wild herbs on which the animals graze. None of the sacrificial lamb goes to waste. Once mass is over, the midnight feast begins with a bowl of *magiritsa* soup, made from lamb's

liver, lungs, head, and intestines, *avgolemono* (egg and lemon) sauce, and seasoned with green onions and dill. This pungent broth prepares the stomach for the meat spree to follow – a kind of digestive purgatory after 40 days of Lenten fasting. The ordeal is sweetened with slices of *tsourekí*, a braided brioche flavored with the resinous sap of the mastic tree, and *lychnarakia*, sweet cheese pies shaped like miniature toques.

Traditionally, the Easter lamb is marinated in olive oil, lemon, and oregano, then roasted whole on a spit. This laborious process is an essential part of the culinary ritual: a pit must be dug, a fire built, then everyone must take a turn at the spit (secretly tearing off bits of crispy skin). It takes several hours for the lamb to cook; meanwhile, hard-boiled eggs, dyed red to represent the blood of Christ, are cracked open, wine is drunk, songs are sung, and cigarettes are smoked. Squeamish cooks and lazy restaurateurs often slow-roast a leg of lamb in the oven instead – but the result is almost as good. Potato wedges drenched in lemon and garlic are tucked into the cooking dish, and a simple green salad with a zingy lemon dressing is all that's required on the side. It would be almost sacrilegious to serve anything else.

Three Days on Tinos

The travel writer Lawrence Durrell dubbed Tinos “the Lourdes of modern Greece.” But with spectacular vernacular architecture, a thriving crafts industry, and scores of sandy beaches, there's much more than churches to explore.

DAY ONE There are around 50 villages on Tinos – each one lovelier than the last. Buy baskets in **Volax**, where cottages crouch beneath colossal boulders. Visit the Museum of Marble Crafts in **Pyrgos**, where every doorway bristles with sculpted marble birds, boats, and hearts; the village is also famous for *galaktoboureko*, sticky custard pie.

DAY TWO Admire some of the island's 800 carved, decorated dovecotes, found everywhere. Visit the Venetian fortress at craggy **Exobourgo**; return to Tinos town and light a candle at **Panagia Evangelistria** before visiting the neighboring bazaar.

DAY THREE Aeolos, god of the winds, allegedly resides on **Mount Tsiknias**, the island's highest peak. Make the most of winds at the surf school on **Kolimithra beach**, or head for a sandy cove such as **Livada**, **Apigania**, or **Pachia Ammos**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

There is no airport; **ferries** from Athens take 3–5 hours. You'll need to rent a **car** to explore.

WHERE TO STAY

Tinion (inexpensive) in Tinos town is a basic but charming *pension*. www.tinionhotel.gr

Vega Apartments (moderate) in Agios Markos offer vacation rentals in sleek Cycladic style. www.vegaapartments.gr

Anthia (expensive) is a family-friendly hotel with a pool and restaurant, close to Agios Fokas beach. www.anthia.gr

FURTHER INFORMATION

www.tinos.gr

